

Expository Writing

Critical Response Essay

Week 2

Purpose of a Critical Response Essay

-is an important type of academic essay to gauge the students' ability to *read*, *react*, and *respond critically* and *express their opinions*
- presents a *writer's reaction to the content* of an article, text, book, story, film, artwork, play, performance, or any other piece of writing.
- goes *beyond mere summary* and *response*.
- requires the writer to engage deeply with the material to *assess its merits* and *shortcomings* (Wallace & Wray, 2021).
- main purpose of CRE is to develop a reasoned argument that expresses the writer's analysis and critique.
- a critical response to a piece of any text under review demands an analysis, interpretation, and synthesis of a reading (Ogbonnaya & Brown, 2023).

Purpose of a Critical Response Essay

- Mostly, students assume that a critical reaction revolves around the identification of flaws, **BUT** this aspect only represents one dimension of writing (Davies, 2022).
- Instead it should *identify both the strengths* and *weaknesses* of the work under analysis and present them without exaggerating their significance.
- *Find a stance* to take with your response
- Do not repeat main points or write a summary
- Craft your perspective into the argument
- Use something unique/interesting to say about what you read.
- Tell your audience *why* it's unique and interesting.

Writing a Critical Response Essay Involves...

1. **Critical Reading**

- Identifying the ideas, organization, and purpose of the reading

2. **Critical Thinking**

- Analyzing and evaluating the reading and ideas

3. **Reacting in Writing**

- Identifying the reading's key ideas
- Stating opinion about a particular part or all of the reading
- Supporting your opinion with appropriate details, quotations, and explanations

Steps to Writing a Critical Response Essay

- **Step 1:**
- Look for answers to the following questions as you read it the first time:
 1. What is the topic and the main problem or issue that the author is addressing?
 2. What is the author's central claim, argument, or point?
 3. What assumptions does the author make?
 4. What evidence does the author present?
- **Step 2:**
- as you read it the second time write your ideas and answers to the following questions:
 1. How do I feel about what is being said?
 2. Is the author's claim supported sufficiently?
 3. Do I agree or disagree with the author?
 4. What are possible counterarguments to the reading's claims?

Steps to Writing a Critical Response Essay

- **Step 3:**
- Write a draft of the summary of the reading...
- Paraphrase:
 - The author's thesis
 - Main supporting ideas
 - Important details (only)
- **Step 4:**
- Write your **opinion** about or **reaction** to the reading
- **Step 5:**
- Write the first draft of the Critical Response Essay

Components of a Critical Response Essay

Follow 5 Paragraph Essay Structure

- Introductory Paragraph
- Body Paragraph 1
- Body Paragraph 2
- Body Paragraph 3
- Concluding Paragraph

Introductory Paragraph

Statement/s 1-2

- Details of work
- Name of story/article/book
- Name of author
- Other details such as Year of publication *if available*

Statement 3-4

Lead-in

- Summary/main idea of original work

Statement 5

Three-point thesis statement

1. Claim (based on evaluation of text/your opinion),

Your three-point arguments may focus on anyone of the following:

- ☐ authors' language/assumptions/evidence
- ☐ Ambiguity and Interpretation
- ☐ Themes, ideas, concept
- ☐ Agreement/disagreement
- ☐ Adding a New Perspective

2. Three reasons to support your claim

Statement 6

Transitional Hook

Single sentence, built on first point of thesis, leading to body paragraph 1.

Body Paragraphs

1. Paragraph one: Supporting detail # 1
2. Paragraph two: Supporting detail # 2
3. Paragraph three: Supporting detail # 3

Start with a topic sentence (supporting detail) to explain the opinion you expressed in your thesis

Contains a clear topic and 2 controlling ideas/transitional hooks

Clearly relates to the thesis statement

Includes sufficient details/examples/quotes from the reading to explain your point

Concluding Paragraph

- Restates your thesis (point of view)
- Summarizes the main idea
- Offer a broader perspective
- Leave a lasting impression

In Class Reading

Read the Essay :

“Why We Crave Horror Movies” by Stephen King

Page: 498, Models for Writers 14th Edition



Thesis Statements based on Different Focus

- In “Why We Crave Horror Movies” Stephen King effectively uses conversational language, vivid metaphors, and personal anecdotes to engage readers (**Author’s language/Assumptions/Evidence**)
- Stephen King’s “Why We Crave Horror Movies” presents an ambiguous argument that critiques societal norms, rationalizes the appeal of horror, and explores human psychology. (**Ambiguity and Interpretation**)
- In “Why We Crave Horror Movies,” Stephen King explores the themes of emotional catharsis, societal repression, and human fascination with fear. (**Themes, Ideas, and Concepts**)
- In “Why We Crave Horror Movies” Stephen King effectively argues that horror films provide emotional catharsis, allow viewers to safely confront their fears, and satisfy our primal instincts. (**Agreement**)
- While Stephen King’s “Why We Crave Horror Movies” persuasively argues that horror provides catharsis and confronts fears, his claim that everyone craves horror oversimplifies cultural preferences, dismisses its negative impacts, and ignores alternative emotional outlets. (**Disagreement**)

Specimen Critical Response Essay

Introductory Paragraph

In 1982, Stephen King, the master of horror, delved into the psychology of fear with his insightful essay, "Why We Crave Horror Movies". King, renowned for his chilling novels, offers a unique perspective on our attraction to the macabre. Stephen King explores the psychological and social reasons that drive our fascination with the horror genre in the essay. King effectively uses vivid imagery to convey complex emotions, create a lasting impression, and heighten the reader's sense of suspense. The use of imagery and atmosphere effectively conveys profound dread, in the chilling landscapes.

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1. *Details about work (name of essay, author and year of publication.*
2. **Summary of original work**
3. *Three point thesis statement*
4. **Transitional hook**

Assignment



Assignment 1 to be taken in Week 3